

DANCE FOR MY HOSTS 353D Project

The intention of this dance is to tell a personal story of discovery. I was raised in Burnaby and Deer Lake Park is of special significance to me. I spent much of my childhood playing in the gardens there and I have walked around the lake hundreds of times. Most importantly, I learned to dance at the Shadbolt Centre for the Arts which sits just south-west of the lake. Despite all of the time I spent at this beautiful spot, I never learned about its rich Indigenous history until very recently. A few years ago, I came across E. Pauline Johnson's book, *Legends of Vancouver*, in which she shares a Squamish legend about Deer Lake.¹ The story follows the first Chief Capilano who, while sailing along Point Grey, encounters a "king of seals". The Chief decides to use his most prized weapon, an elk-bone spear attached to a cedar-fiber rope, to kill the great seal. But when the Chief launches the spear, the seal does not die but plunges into the sea, dragging the Chief and his canoe all the way to False Creek. There, the seal leaps into the air before plunging deep again, breaking the rope. The elk-bone spear is lost as the seal king escapes. The next year, the Chief sees a fire burning in the distance and follows the flames to Deer Lake where the "little body of water [is] surrounded by forest fires". The Chief passes a moving mass of beavers running away from the fire, journeying north. As he reaches the water's edge, the Chief notices the dead body of the giant seal. He approaches the carcass and sees his forefathers' spear, still embedded in the decaying flesh! As he extracts the spear, he is overcome with a feeling of great power and sits by the seal's body chanting songs while the fire slowly subsides. For years, the Chief searches in vain for the hidden river which led the great seal from False Creek to Deer Lake. Though the people of the Squamish tribe "tell and believe that the river still sings through its hidden trail that leads from Deer Lake to the sea, its course is as unknown, its channel is as hopelessly lost as the brave little army of beavers that a century ago marshalled their forces and travelled up into the great lone north".

Though there are many more legends in Johnson's book featuring other places which I grew up knowing and visiting, I decided to focus my project on Deer Lake. Performing the piece on site at Deer Lake symbolizes the evolution of my perspective of the park from childhood to the present. As a child, Deer Lake felt like part of my home; the place where I played and danced. In recent years however, upon learning about the colonial history of Burnaby and reading the *Legends of Vancouver*, my feelings about familiar places, including Deer Lake, have changed. When I go to Deer Lake now, I no longer feel entitled to call it home. Rather, I recognize it as belonging to the *hən̓ q̓ əm̓n̓ əm* and *Sḵw̓xwú7mesh* speaking Peoples. The significance that the lake holds for me pales in comparison to what it means to the Indigenous groups whose ancestors lived and thrived there for thousands of years. For the *hən̓ q̓ əm̓n̓ əm* and *Sḵw̓xwú7mesh* Peoples, Deer Lake was a place to harvest cranberries, fish for salmon and trout and hunt ducks, elk, deer, beaver and migratory birds.² Deer Lake was also a site of Indigenous oppression throughout the 20th century because thousands of Indigenous prisoners were incarcerated at the Oakalla Prison Farm on the lakefront.³ In short, I am an uninvited guest at Deer Lake. This piece is an attempt to recognize Deer Lake as a place which I am grateful to access but which does not belong to me. In performing this piece on site at Deer Lake, I give thanks to the peoples who found and cared for this land and I express my deep sadness that it was stolen from them.

¹ E. Pauline Johnson (Tekahionwake), *Legends of Vancouver*, (Toronto: McClelland & Stewart, 1931).

² *Indigenous History in Burnaby: Resource Guide*, (Burnaby: Burnaby Village Museum, 2019) at 11 < [Indigenous History in Burnaby Resource Guide.pdf](#)>.

³ *Supra* note 2 at 9.

Song Choice

For days, I searched for a song to choreograph to. I came across this song, the Coast Salish Anthem or Chief Dan George's Prayer Song on YouTube.⁴ Chief Dan George of the Tsleil-Waututh Nation taught the Anthem to choir students at Seycove Secondary School in North Vancouver. The arrangement features drumming and singing by Gordon Dick, also of the Tsleil-Waututh Nation. The words of a speech delivered by Chief Dan George in 1967 and entitled *Lament for Confederation* are included in the video description.

I decided to use this arrangement of the Coast Salish Anthem because the Tsleil-Waututh Nation is one of the Indigenous Nations with claims to Deer Lake. It also seemed more appropriate to use a version of the song performed by settlers since I am a settler myself. I also wanted the feeling, spirit and message of *Lament for Confederation* to inform this piece.

Movement Guide and Symbolism

Section 1: Ignorance (0:00 – 0:53)

The piece begins with me on a balcony of the Shadbolt Centre with Deer Lake in the background. The movements in this section of the piece take up a lot of space, are quick and frenzied with a juvenile and excited quality. There are a lot of jumps, reaches and stretches. These movements are intended to represent child-like, unfettered entitlement to the land on which I was raised, including Deer Lake.

Section 2: Revelation (0:53 – 2:29)

My joyful and free movements are suddenly interrupted as I turn to face the lake with my arms reaching out. I very slowly drop my arms to my sides as the camera comes in closer. This sequence symbolizes the realization that this land is not mine. It is a slow and painful revelation. Next, you will see me reach my hand out and then bring it back towards my head. I do this several times to symbolize all of the things I have learned about Deer Lake and its significance to local Indigenous Peoples. I reach out my hands to collect this knowledge and bring it back to my brain so that it may inform how I view and live on these lands. As I come full circle, I reach both hands out towards the lake in hopes of being worthy of continuing to receive such knowledge and understanding.

The next sequence begins as my body drops, after which my movements become smaller, more grounded and confined to the immediate space. I cave into myself, stay hunched and low to the ground. These movements reflect my instinctual habit to make myself smaller and less conspicuous because I am unsure whether I am welcome here. Overall, this part of the piece represents the feelings of guilt, shame, hopelessness, sadness and despair that Chief Dan George expresses in his *Lament for Confederation* and that I experienced as I learned more about colonization and the irreparable harm it caused Indigenous peoples who lived here.

Section 3: Responsibility (2:29 - 3:18)

The next pattern of movement represents a humble acceptance of the responsibility to keep learning about the Indigenous histories of the lands on which I live and to give deference and gratitude to the Indigenous caretakers. Accordingly, I kneel and gently place my hands on the ground. Next, to show

⁴ Melodie Langevin. "Coast Salish Anthem | Chief Dan George's Prayer Song," (1 July 2020), online: *YouTube* <https://youtu.be/sQk-rVgnW_I>.

respect for the legend of Deer Lake, I stretch one leg, keeping one hand on my ribcage in an effort to personify the speared seal king from the legend of Deer Lake.

I rise up slowly, signaling the final, short sequence of the piece which represents my newfound perspective on Deer Lake, largely informed by the legend that I read in Johnson's book. Though no longer hunched in shame, my movements remain small, timid and polite. I am still not comfortable here. I bring my arms into my body and execute a small circular sway; a last recognition of my positionality. Finally, I reach my arms out with my heart open to the water to represent my gratitude for Deer Lake and my vow to always regard it, not as my own, but as belonging to those whose ancestors cared for it since time immemorial.